

NEOMI RAO

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EDUCATION

- 2020-present University of Chicago
PhD candidate, Political Science
Dissertation: Carceral Racial Capitalism and the Radical Politics of Abolitionist Organizing in Post-Industrial Chicago
Advisor: Dr. Cathy J. Cohen
- 2018-2019 University of Chicago
Master of Arts Program in Social Sciences (MAPSS)
Thesis: “Communities Change When Individuals Change”: The Sustainability of System-Challenging Collective Action
- 2012-2016 University of Maryland College Park
Bachelor of Arts, Linguistics, magna cum laude
Bachelor of Science, General Biology, magna cum laude
Phi Beta Kappa

PUBLICATIONS

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

- 2024 Plotkin, S., Krishnan, S., Hui, K. & Rao N. (2024). Collective Drawing as Liberatory Method: An Abolitionist Toolkit for Community Meaning-Making, designed with CareNotCops. *Theory, Research, and Action in Urban Education, Special Issue: Black Geographies and Transdisciplinary Abolitionist Education: Lifting Up Interlocking Struggles to Create Radical Possibilities.*
- 2021 Rao, N. & Power, S. A. (2021). “Communities Change When Individuals Change”: The Sustainability of System-Challenging Collective Action. *European Journal of Social Psychology.*
- 2020 Rao, N. & Lingam, L. (2020). Smartphones, Youth, and Moral Panics: Exploring Print and Online Media Narratives in India. *Mobile Media & Communication.*
- 2020 Rao, N. (2020). Effect of pre- and post-paid incentives on mail survey response. *Survey Practice.*

REVISED & RESUBMITTED ARTICLES

- 2026 **Rao, N.** (in revision) Transforming Safety as Abolitionist Ideological Work. *SOULS: A Critical Journal of Black Politics, Culture, and Society.*

PRESENTATIONS

CONFERENCE TALKS

- 2026 **Rao, N.** Learning to be New Humans: Antidotes from Chicago's Abolitionist Organizers. Forum for the Study of Organizing and Collective Action, 2026. Minneapolis, MN.
- 2025 **Rao, N. & Perez J.** Abolitionist Organizing and Political Consequences in Chicago. Midwestern Political Science Association (MPSA) Annual Conference 2025. Chicago, IL.
- 2025 **Rao, N.** Transforming safety as abolitionist ideological work. Southern Political Science Association (SPSA) Annual Conference 2025. San Juan, PR.
- 2023 **Rao, N.** The emergence of the demand to defund police on Twitter. Western Political Science Association (WPSA) Annual Conference 2023. San Francisco, CA.
- 2019 **Rao, N. & Ulrich, K.** Effect of pre- and post-paid incentives on mail survey response. Midwest Association for Public Opinion Research (MAPOR) 44th Annual Conference. Chicago, IL.

POSTER PRESENTATIONS

- 2026 **Rao, N.** Structural Violence and Radical Resistance in 20th Century Chicago. American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Conference 2026. Boston, MA.

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

- 2026-2027 Joint Dissertation Completion Fellowship, University of Chicago Center for the Study of Race, Politics, and Culture (CSRPC) and Center for Sexuality and Gender Studies (CSGS) (\$5000)
- 2025-2026 Residential Fellowship, University of Chicago CSRPC
- 2025, 2026 Travel and Research Grant, University of Chicago CSRPC (\$3500)
- 2023-2024 Graduate Fellowship, University of Chicago Pozen Center for Human Rights (\$5000)
- 2023 Graduate Fellowship, University of Chicago GRAD Global Impact Pitch Internship, CORO India (\$6000)
- 2023 APSA Political Communication Section Travel Award (\$750)
- 2022, 2023 Reimagine the University Grant, University of Chicago CSRPC (\$5000)
- 2018-19 Merit-based Scholarship of Full Tuition, University of Chicago, MAPSS (\$57,996)
- 2012-2016 Banneker/Key Merit-based Scholarship of Full Tuition, University of Maryland College Park (\$80,000)

TEACHING

INSTRUCTOR, PRISON + NEIGHBORHOOD ARTS/EDUCATION PROJECT

- Spring 2026 The Art of Personal Narrative taught at Logan Correctional Center, Lincoln, IL
- Co-Instructors: Alice Kim & Wendy Clinard

TEACHING ASSISTANT, UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO

- Fall 2026 Politics of the U.S. Congress
- Primary Instructor: Dr. John Mark Hansen
- Spring 2025 Community Engaged Course: Narratives of Incarceration and Justice
- Primary Instructors: Alice Kim & James Soto
- Spring 2024 Mixed Enrollment Course: Research, Writing, and Mass Incarceration taught at Stateville Correctional Center, Crest Hill, IL
- Primary Instructors: Alice Kim & Dr. Cathy J. Cohen
- Fall 2023 Interpretive Methods
- Primary Instructor: Dr. Lisa Wedeen

PEDAGOGICAL TRAINING

- Fall 2025 Centering Race Consortium, Teaching Race Pedagogy Series

ADDITIONAL RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- 9/2024-1/2026 Research Consultant and Project Manager, Mapping Repression in Higher Education Project, Scholars for Social Justice
Supervisor: Dr. Saudi Garcia
- 8/2021-8/2022 Senior Research Assistant, University of Chicago Reimagining Public Safety on Campus Project
Supervisor: Dr. Eve Ewing
- 1/2021-12/2021 Research Assistant, University of Chicago Political Economy and Race Lab
Supervisor: Dr. Patricia Posey
- 9/2017-8/2018 Research Assistant, Tata Institute of Social Sciences, Mumbai, Adolescent Subcultures and Smartphones Project
Supervisor: Dr. Lakshmi Lingam

RELATED PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

- 6/2023-12/2025 Intern and Graduate Fellow, Prison+Neighborhood Arts/Education Project & Beyond Prisons at CSRPC, University of Chicago, Chicago IL
Supervisor: Alice Kim

8/2019-8/2020 Survey Specialist, NORC at the University of Chicago, Chicago IL
Supervisor: Dr. Amie Conley

10/2018-8/2019 Operations Assistant, University of Chicago Survey Lab
Supervisors: Dr. Martha Van Haitsma and Kevin Ulrich

9/2017-8/2018 Communications Coordinator, CORO India, Mumbai
Supervisor: Dr. Sujata Khandekar

SERVICE

2024-2026 Convener and Coordinator, Abolition and Carceralties Study Group,
University of Chicago CSRPC

2023-2025 Departmental Steward, Graduate Students United - United Electric Local 1103

2022-2023 Co-President, Graduate Students United - United Electric Local 1103

PROFESSIONAL ASSOCIATIONS

American Political Science Association

Western Political Science Association

Southern Political Science Association

REFERENCES

Dr. Cathy J. Cohen
D. Gale Johnson Distinguished
Service Professor of Political
Science and Professor of Race,
Diaspora, and Indigeneity
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Dr. Lisa Wedeen
Mary R. Morton Distinguished
Service Professor, Department
of Political Science and the
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Dr. Adom Getachew
Professor of Political
Science and Interim Chair,
Department of Race,
Diaspora, and Indigeneity
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